natural desire to shape the direction of Pakistani politics. But given the cards it held, even contemporary observers were surprised at the outcome. It took some time for the negative implications to unfold, but even as they did, India's assertion of its interests was more forceful than in the past. A decisive move on the Siachen glacier dealt with a growing concern. With Sri Lanka, anxiety at the ethnic conflict was sought to be translated into a settlement guaranteed by India. That the initiative went wrong is a different matter; undertaking it in itself was an act of no small confidence. When Maldives was attacked by mercenaries, India chose to respond by sending in troops in consultation with other powers. Whether it was in respect of South Asia or China, India moved to defend its equities in national security. A diplomatic campaign was also waged to limit the presence of extra-regional navies in the Indian Ocean. The overall picture emerges of a growing regional power protective of its interests, but also more hopeful about creating a responsive neighbourhood.

This is not to suggest that things went India's way all through this period. The assassination of Sheikh Mujib in Dhaka in August 1975 significantly neutralized the gains of 1971. The politics of the Cold War also combined with Pakistan's mobilization of the Islamic world to block India at the Security Council elections of 1975. The Chinese attack on Vietnam in 1979 temporarily halted the correction in India's policy and perhaps undermined a serious overture in the making. The Soviet occupation of Afghanistan was even more complicating because it unleashed a new round of American military support for Pakistan. Indeed, this round was particularly devastating because it tapped into a larger Islamic fundamentalist resurgence. Sino-Pakistani collaboration that had receded when China was preoccupied with the Cultural Revolution also came back into play. Its three key elements were the physical link-up between the two countries through the Karakoram Highway in 1979, the intense nuclear and missile collaboration, and the coordination in respect to operations in Afghanistan. All of them have consequences to the present day for India.

Almost as significant was China's decision to change its position on the boundary negotiations in respect of the eastern sector. The renewed enmity of Pakistan combined with the hostility of the West on the Afghan issue also provided fertile ground for the external growth of the Khalistan